# Bushfires and Australian ecosystems

Australia is a very hot and dry country. In the summer months, bushfires threaten natural habitats all over Australia. Sometimes bushfires start because of lightning strikes or other natural processes. Other times they are deliberately lit and controlled by authorities. Indigenous Australians used controlled burns for thousands of years before Europeans came to Australia.

Although fire destroys some plants in an ecosystem, it encourages other plants to grow. Fire heats up the seed pods of certain trees and plants, such as the banksia plant. When the pressure inside the pod builds up, it bursts open and releases its seeds, which begins a new crop of trees.

Some animals in an ecosystem benefit from bushfires too. Fire encourages new plants to grow and it can reduce animal numbers, which means there is more food and less competition for the surviving animals. Fire also clears old vegetation (plant growth), creating new habitats and shelters for animals.

☞ **1** In which season do most bushfires occur in Australia? Circle your answer.

autumn winter spring summer

**2** What important function do fires have in some parts of the Australian bush? Write your answer below, using the sentence starter to help you.

The heat from bushfires can cause seed pods to _____

_____.

**3** Fill in the missing letters to complete these facts about bushfires and ecosystems.

**a)** A __ __ __ r __ __ ia has many bushfires each year.

**b)** Bushfires can be caused by __ __ ghtn __ __ __ strikes.

**c)** B __ nks __ __ pl __ nts need fire so their s __ __ ds can germinate, or begin to shoot and gr __ w.

**d)** F __ r __ __ can destroy the h __ b __ __ __ __ s of many animal species, but they can also create n__w h__b__t__ts.

**e)** Eucalyptus trees contain oils that make their leaves __ __ rn fiercely.

**f)** Some plants can r __ c __ v __ r from bushfires, some are destroyed permanently and some n__ __d bushfires to r__pr__d__c__.

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ISBN 978 1 92571 064 9